



IMMIGRANTS WAITING AT A REFUGEE CENTRE IN ITALY

REUTERS

DELHI | The Italian Job

With two high profile ministers in the Foreign Office still coping with checkout blues, Minister of State for External Affairs Preneet Kaur is holding fort on key issues. So, when Italy recently announced an amnesty scheme to regularise illegal immigrants, the Indian mission in Rome sent an sos to Delhi that they didn't have enough personnel to manage the papers of thousands of Indians seeking verification. Under the scheme, illegal immigrants can stay in Italy only if they prove their nationality. For that, the Indian mission in Rome and consulate in Milan have to send the papers to the respective states to reconfirm nationality. Even though Italy does not fall under her charge and is handled by Shashi Tharoor, Kaur called Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao and asked her to find a way. Setting a precedent, almost a dozen officials have been sent to Italy to help these immigrants take the legal route.

by Saurabh Shukla

MUMBAI | Tech Race

Door-to-door campaigning is passé. In a bid to attract more voters in the upcoming Maharashtra Assembly polls, the BJP's IT cell, comprising MBAs, IITians and IIM graduates, recently organised a live chat for netizens with BJP state President Nitin Gadkari that saw one lakh people logging on. The Congress' media cell is also now equipped with the facility to send out two lakh SMSes at one go. The Shiv Sena is also seeking online feedback from citizens on what they expect in the party manifesto.

by Nishika Patel

KERALA'S SCHEME TO REHABILITATE THOSE RETURNING HOME AFTER LOSING THEIR JOBS IN THE GULF HAS FEW TAKERS.

KERALA | Surprised Package

The Rs 100-crore loan package announced by the state Government to rehabilitate those returning jobless from the Gulf after the recession has fallen flat on its face. Three months after the announcement, there have been just four takers—this when the anticipated applicants were expected to cross five lakh. Most of the 20,000 returnees are construction labourers who have neither the inclination nor the education to start their own businesses. The number of returnees registered with the state Government's Department for Non-Resident Welfare is just 1,110. The loan scheme is likely to wind up much before 2010, the year it was officially slated to end.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

DELHI | Back in Business

The seven-year itch has finally ended with the Delhi Stock Exchange (DSE) all set to commence trading by Diwali. Activities on this exchange which was incorporated in 1947 came to a halt in 2002. With a daily turnover target of Rs 1,000 crore in its first year, the DSE will now allow trading by the more than 3,000 companies on its "rolls/ rosters". The DSE's deposit-based trading membership scheme, being offered with an amnesty programme to revive inactive stocks and encourage compliance, has got an enthusiastic response, says DSE executive director H.S. Sidhu. The DSE is also in talks with Standard & Poor's for developing a primary index on the lines of the Sensex and Nifty50.

by Nivedita Mukherjee



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